

Tactical Choice in Repeated Protests

Elaine Yao (Washington University in St. Louis)

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- ▶ From an applied standpoint, this paper is about **why protests choose and change tactics over time**, especially once they start losing momentum and mobilization
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 - Normal experimentation: DM chooses among technologies not only for their immediate payoff, but for how info revealed by their outcomes could improve subsequent choices
- ▶ The connection: Technologies (tactics) endogenously degrade **because they depend upon** individuals' willingness to participate in a protest, which decreases as the movement experiences more failures

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- ▶ Hence tactics reflect a dynamic tradeoff: **Which tactic is strongest now? Which will remain valuable if mobilization deteriorates later?**
- ▶ What this can say about the real world: **Structures that shape the kinds of tactics available, plus the importance of public opinion to mobilization, generate different paths of tactical choice**

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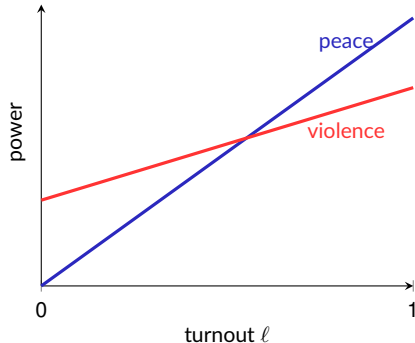
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- ▶ Protest succeeds if protest power exceeds regime strength
- ▶ If period 1 fails, citizens update and the movement tries again; period 2 is terminal

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- ▶ Assume **for this talk** that these are linear: $A_p(\ell) = \ell$, $A_v(\ell) = \alpha + \beta\ell$
- ▶ $\alpha + \beta < 1$ (peace has a ceiling advantage)



Participation and cost signals

- ▶ Citizen i privately observes a participation cost

$$C_{it} = C_t + \epsilon_{it}$$

- ▶ $c_t \sim Unif[-\epsilon, 1 + \epsilon]$ is a **common participation-cost shock**: conditions that make protest easier or harder for everyone.
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- ▶ Citizens observe only their own total cost c_{it} , shocks are i.i.d across citizens and periods

Participation payoffs

- ▶ A participant receives benefit 1 if the protest succeeds and pays participation cost regardless of the outcome:

$$u_{it} = \begin{cases} 1 - c_{it}, & \text{participate and succeed,} \\ -c_{it}, & \text{participate and fail,} \\ 0, & \text{do not participate.} \end{cases}$$

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- ▶ Why this structure?
 - ▶ Repeated global games with public learning often reintroduce multiplicity (Angeletos, Hellwig and Pavan 2007; Little 2017)
 - ▶ Here, participation is driven by private information about costs; this + support assumptions guarantee global games properties
 - ▶ **Result: individual's within-period participation decision is cutoff at each history**

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3. Protest occurs; turnout and outcome are public
4. If the protest succeeds, the game ends. If else, either start over (if period 1), or game ends if period 2)

We will look for a PBE.

Foundational results (you don't need tactical choice for these)

1. I participate if $c_{it} < \hat{c}_t \equiv \int_0^1 F(A(\ell_t)) dt$

- **Key:** the threshold **depends on current beliefs about θ**

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3. Bigger failures are more informative $\implies$ the regime is almost certainly very strong $\implies$ expected turnout goes down by a lot
4. Hence a tradeoff: Bigger protest today = bigger chance of success, but also bigger damage to public confidence if it fails
 - Tactical choice can **manipulate and respond to** this trade-off

Three levers of tactical choice

Recall: Violence = $\alpha + \beta * \text{turnout}$, Peace = turnout.

Param	What it captures	Dynamic role
α	baseline violent power	Insurance when turnout is poor
β	violent returns to turnout	Reason to use violence while turnout is expected to be high
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 - ▶ Higher β makes violence attractive while mobilization is strong
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- ▶ The combination of these three levers dictates how tactics are chosen

Summary of some results

- ▶ **Continuation choice can be path-dependent.**
 - Weak failures favor violence as a low-turnout fallback, whereas strong failures favor peace because they select for stronger regimes
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► Opening tactics depend on mobilization fragility.

- When turnout is resilient to beliefs, sufficiently scalable violence can be used immediately; when turnout is fragile, peace is always used first
- Hence, even if violence is very strong, it still may not be used in the first period

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- ▶ **Case 1: turnout is ultra-robust**
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- ▶ **Case 2: turnout is ultra-fragile**
 - When $\rho \rightarrow 1$, turnout is “all or nothing”
 - Dynamic concern for how tactics might degrade in the future dominates incentive to achieve the most powerful protest today
 - Even very powerful violent technology may not be used first, since it’s “less degradable”

Case 1 - When turnout is **robust**

Suppose $\rho \rightarrow 0$. Then turnout is uniform on $[0, 1]$, independent of beliefs.

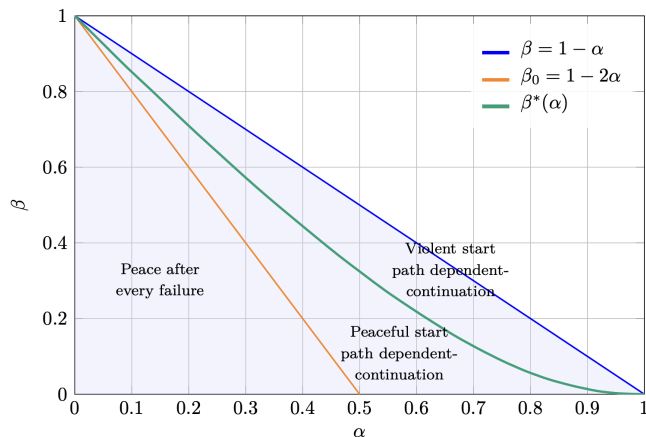


Figure: Orange line: continuation boundary; Green line: Opening boundary

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$\Rightarrow$ *Even if there's big upside, there's huge downside to starting with violence*
- ▶ Hence the organizer begins peacefully for every admissible violent technology

Empirical implications

- ▶ Interventions that **move contention across the parameter environment** can change tactic sequencing and path dependence
 - e.g. Haussmanian renovation transforms Paris; contention shifts from strategies that emphasize barricades and contingent violence to large mass gatherings
 - Changes to the **built environment** and **structure of society** don't just change "the predominant form of tactics," but the **dynamic shape of tactical choice**

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- ▶ Structural/technological factors matter on their own when violence is weak, but **their interaction with the movement's base must be considered when violence is more useful**